

By Sharda Ugra

At one point during his full-throttle, full-volume, Internet-charged and television-laced bullfight during IPL Season 3, Lalit Modi was asked by a member of the IPL Governing Council, "What are you doing? Who are you taking on?"

The man was referring to the Modi haymaker at Shashi Tharoor that dismissed him as "no big deal" in a TV interview, adding that all would be "swatted aside". The former minister for external affairs did have to step down but today it is Modi who is sidelined. In one swift move, the 46-year-old businessman lost his beloved title of IPL Commissioner, the centre of his universe, and went from being its official chairman to just an official suspended from a BCCI sub-committee.

As the final minutes of the IPL final played out, it became clear that with Tharoor gone, Modi had taken on quite a different kind of beast. Moments after the completion of the IPL final, Modi received a suspension notice in an email sent out, in Modi-style, to all corners of cyberspace by BCCI Secretary N. Srinivasan. A presentation ceremony speech then followed in which Modi fell back on Zen philosophy and quoted the Bhagvad Gita. It was meant to stir hearts and minds, but all that remained once the Chennai Super Kings had sung their champagne-soaked team song was the echo of rolling thunder. The peacetime party was over and war had officially been declared.

The BCCI's opening shot came in the form of a replacement for Modi, the IPL's interim chairman Chirayu Amin, 62, president of the Baroda Cricket Association, and a fervent search for missing documents which should have logically been in their own offices. As cricket was reeling from a scandal that was compared to the match-fixing months of madness in 2000, this time with battalions of financial investigators, Amin said, "The success of the IPL was so dazzling that everyone was basking in its glory."

At the moment, Modi is trying to retain his dazzle, tweeting IPL statistics

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(FROM LEFT TO RIGHT) N. SRINIVASAN, SHASHANK MANOHAR AND RAJEEV SHUKLA; (RIGHT) LALIT MODI

and messages to "the fans", switching between Mumbai's Four Seasons Hotel and the Delhi residences of legal heavyweights like Harish Salve and Ram Jethmalani.

The suspense now gathers around Modi's legal case. It is most likely he will include the BCCI's own constitution to work against the IPL's governing council which charged him on counts of financial impropriety to bid rigging. There are chances that more than a few shots could be taken at Srinivasan

and BCCI Vice-President and Congress MP Rajeev Shukla. Or as Modi said in his tweet, "Wait, we have just begun."

Cricket can only hold its breath—and its head. While it waits for the fortnight given to Modi to respond to the show cause, the BCCI's own battery of lawyers will come into play to strengthen their own case, should their former poster boy take them to court. At the moment, former BCCI president A.C. Muthiah has moved the Supreme Court against a controversial amend-